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The Dwarven Debt

An Adventure for Fate's Edge Aeler

Adventure Overview

Title: The Dwarven Debt
Region: Aeler Crowns
UnderVaults
Theme: Underground exploration, dwarven law and custom, ancient bargains
Level: Seasoned to Veteran (Tier IIII)
Length: 45 Sessions

Premise

A dwarven merchant house has called in a debt owed by one of the player characters, demanding they retrieve a sacred artifact from a dangerous section of the Spine Underway. The artifact, a ceremonial hammer known as the Forgefather's Voice, was pledged as collateral decades ago but was never properly transferred according to dwarven law. Now, with the house facing financial difficulties, they're enforcing the ancient contract, forcing the players into the deep places beneath the mountains where ancient dangers still stir.

Hook

The adventure begins when the players encounter one of the following scenarios:

tem ClanSpeaker Thrain Ironhold arrives with a formal delegation to collect on the debt, presenting ancient contracts and demanding immediate compliance under dwarven law. (DV 4 Social encounter, Presence + Command) tem The players' patron sends an urgent message warning them that a dwarven house is making claims on their behalf, and they need to resolve the situation before it escalates. (DV 3 Investigation, Wits + Lore) tem A dwarven prospector approaches them in a tavern, desperately seeking help to recover the same artifact for reasons he won't fully explain. (DV 3 Social, Presence + Sway)

Key Factions

3.1 House KhazVurim

House KhazVurim tem[Description:] One of the oldest and most respected dwarven houses tem[Leader:] VaultQueen Thora Stonebeard tem[Strengths:] Master craftsmen, extensive underground knowledge, legal expertise tem[Motivations:] Honor ancient contracts, maintain financial stability tem[Methods:]

Legal proceedings, measured pressure, traditional dwarven justice tem[Position:] Controlled (normal interactions), may shift to Desperate under financial pressure tem[DV for Negotiations:] 4 (standard), 5 (under pressure)

3.2 The Deep Stirrings

The Deep Stirrings tem[Description:] Ancient entities dwelling in the deepest underground realms tem[Strengths:] Ancient knowledge, supernatural abilities, patience tem[Motivations:] Restore balance, reclaim sacred objects tem[Methods:] Subtle influence, dreams and omens, manipulation through dwarven customs tem[Position:] Dominant in deep places, Limited influence in shallow areas tem[DV for Communication:] 5 (requires proper ritual), 6+ (without preparation)

3.3 Edgewalkers Guild

Edgewalkers Guild tem[Description:] Dwarven prospectors and explorers specializing in new passages tem[Leader:] GuildMaster Thorek Deepdelver tem[Strengths:] Exploration expertise, underground survival skills, flexible ethics tem[Motivations:] Profit, knowledge, guild solidarity tem[Methods:] Competition, information trading, "accidental" discoveries tem[Position:] Controlled (normal), may become Desperate if their interests are threatened tem[DV for Cooperation:] 3 (mutual benefit), 4 (neutral), 5+ (opposed interests)

4 Key NPCs

4.1 VaultQueen Thora Stonebeard

VaultQueen Thora Stonebeard tem[Role:] Leader of House KhazVurim tem[Age:] 62 tem[Skills:] Command 4, Lore 3, Craft 3 tem[Knowledge:] Dwarven law, house finances, artifact history tem[Motivation:] Honor house obligations while preserving tradition tem[Complication:] Torn between legal duty and moral concerns tem[Position:] Controlled (normal), Desperate (under financial pressure) tem[DV for Negotiation:] 4 (standard), 5 (financial pressure)

4.2 ClanSpeaker Thrain Ironhold

ClanSpeaker Thrain Ironhold tem[Role:] Diplomatic representative tem[Age:] 45 tem[Skills:] Sway 3, Lore 3, Command 2 tem[Knowledge:] Dwarven and human law, contract procedures tem[Motivation:] Resolve situation without conflict tem[Complication:] Prepared to enforce house rights if necessary tem[Position:] Dominant (legal expertise), may shift to Controlled under pressure tem[DV for Persuasion:] 3 (mutual benefit), 4 (neutral), 5 (opposed)

4.3 ForgeMaster Durin Emberheart

ForgeMaster Durin Emberheart tem[Role:] Elder master smith tem[Age:] 89 tem[Skills:] Craft 5, Arcana 2, Lore 4 tem[Knowledge:] Artifact creation, true nature of Forgefather's Voice tem[Motivation:] Restore proper balance tem[Complication:] Loyalty conflict between house and conscience tem[Position:] Controlled (normal), may shift to Desperate if pressed about secrets tem[DV for Secrets:] 5 (reluctant), 4 (proper approach), 3 (mutual trust)

4.4 The StoneSinger

The StoneSinger tem[Type:] Ancient Outsider (Cap 5) tem[Tags:] [STONE], [DREAM], [ANCIENT], [WARD] tem[Abilities:]

tem Communicate through stone resonance tem Influence dreams and memories tem Manipulate stone and earth tem Ancient knowledge of underground realms

tem[Weaknesses:] Bound to stone, vulnerable to surface disruption tem[Tactics:] Prefer manipulation to direct confrontation tem[Position:] Dominant in stonerich environments tem[DV for Communication:] 5 (proper ritual), 6+ (improper approach)

5 Key Locations

5.1 KhazVurim Halls

KhazVurim Halls tem[Description:] Ancestral home carved from massive stone formation tem[Features:] Perfect stonework, intricate metalwork, distant forge sounds tem[Atmosphere:] Solemn dignity, ancient tradition tem[Challenges:]

tem Navigating dwarven protocol (Lore + Presence vs DV 3) tem Understanding legal documents (Lore vs DV 4) tem Gaining audience with leadership (Sway + Command vs DV 4)

tem[Security:] Wellguarded, but respectful of proper procedures

5.2 The Spine Underway

The Spine Underway tem[Description:] Vast network of ancient tunnels connecting dwarven holds tem[Features:] Remnants of predwarven civilizations, maintained and dangerous sections tem[Navigation Challenges:]

tem Map reading in three dimensions (Survival vs DV 4) tem Avoiding unstable sections (Athletics vs DV 3) tem Dealing with ancient mechanisms (Tinker vs DV 5)

tem[Dangers:] Caveins, ancient guardians, tem[Position:] Controlled (familiar paths), Desperate (unknown areas)

5.3 The Forgefather's Crypt

The Forgefather's Crypt tem[Description:] Sacred resting place of the Forgefather's Voice tem[Protection:] Ancient wards, ceremonial locks tem[Features:] Remains of original forgefather, deep power resonance tem[Challenges:]

tem Respecting sacred protocols (Lore vs DV 5) tem Dealing with disturbed wards (Arcana vs DV 6) tem Communicating with Deep Stirrings (Spirit + Lore vs DV 5)

tem[Position:] Desperate (sacred violation), may improve with proper approach

5.4 Vault of Whispers

Vault of Whispers tem[Description:] Ancient archive of sacred and dangerous knowledge tem[Security:] Multiple locks, guardian constructs tem[Features:] Records of original agreement, true artifact history tem[Challenges:]

tem Gaining access (Sway + Command vs DV 5) tem Interpreting ancient texts (Lore vs DV 4) tem Avoiding dangerous knowledge (Spirit vs DV 4)

tem[Position:] Desperate (security violations), Controlled with proper credentials

5.5 The Living Stone Gallery

The Living Stone Gallery tem[Description:] Tunnel section where stone responds to sound and movement tem[Connection:] Threshold to Deep Stirrings' domain tem[Features:] Soundresponsive stone, increased activity near artifact tem[Challenges:]

tem Moving without triggering responses (Stealth vs DV 4) tem Interpreting stonesong (Arcana vs DV 5) tem Surviving stone manipulation (Athletics vs DV 4)

tem[Position:] Controlled (careful movement), Desperate (loud/dishonorable actions)

6 Plot Structure

6.1 Session 1: The Debt Called

Opening Scene: Players encounter one of the hook scenarios. Establish the legal and cultural framework of dwarven society.

Key Objectives:

tem Learn about the history of the debt and Forgefather's Voice tem Meet key dwarven NPCs and understand motivations tem Explore legal and social implications tem Make initial decisions about approach

Sample Encounters:

tem **Legal Consultation:** ClanSpeaker explains contract details. (Sway + Lore vs DV 4, Controlled/Standard) tem **House Tour:** Navigate dwarven protocol and customs. (Lore + Presence vs DV 3, Dominant/Limited) tem **Financial Crisis:** Witness House KhazVurim's desperation. (Notice + Insight vs DV 4, Controlled/Standard)

Session End: Players understand the debt's validity but learn there may be complications. Advance Debt Resolution Timer +1.

6.2 Session 2: Into the Deep

Opening Scene: Players begin journey into Spine Underway. First signs of supernatural disturbance appear.

Key Objectives:

tem Navigate complex underground environment tem Encounter first supernatural disturbances tem Deal with timecreated obstacles tem Begin understanding artifact's true nature

Sample Encounters:

tem **Ancient Mechanism:** Repair or bypass old dwarven security. (Tinker + Wits vs DV 5, Controlled/Standard) tem **Lost Prospector:** Edgewalkers Guild member seeks same artifact. (Social encounter, DV 35 depending on approach) tem **Stone Whispering:** First contact with Deep Stirrings' influence. (Spirit + Arcana vs DV 4, Desperate/Limited)

Session End: Players reach deeper areas, supernatural presence becomes clear. Advance StoneSong Resonance +1.

6.3 Session 3: The Deep Stirrings

Opening Scene: Players reach area of maximum Deep Stirrings activity. Direct supernatural contact occurs.

Key Objectives:

tem Experience direct contact with ancient entities tem Learn true history of Forgefather's Voice tem Face moral choices about artifact's fate tem Navigate dwarven customs and ancient laws

Sample Encounters:

tem **StoneSong Communication:** Speak with The StoneSinger. (Arcana + Spirit vs DV 5, Desperate/Great) tem **Ancient Guardian:** Deal with construct protecting sacred areas. (Combat/Skill challenge, DV 5) tem **Moral Dilemma:** Choose between dwarven law and supernatural justice. (Command + Insight vs DV 4)

Session End: Players understand all stakeholder positions. Advance all timers +1.

6.4 Session 4: Resolution

Opening Scene: Players return to dwarven halls with knowledge and options.

Key Objectives:

tem Present findings to dwarven authorities tem Negotiate solution satisfying all parties tem Deal with consequences of choices tem Determine future relationship with dwarven realm

Sample Encounters:

tem **Legal Hearing:** Present case before dwarven council. (Command + Lore vs DV 5, Controlled/Great) tem **Final Negotiation:** Last chance to broker deal with all parties. (Sway + Insight vs DV 5, Desperate/Great) tem **Artifact Decision:** Final choice about Forgefather's Voice fate. (Extended ritual challenge, DV 6)

Session End: Resolution implemented, consequences determined. Timers advance/retreat based on outcome.

7 Key Mechanics**7.1 Debt Resolution Timer [8]**

tem[Advance +1:] House KhazVurim faces increasing financial pressure tem[Advance +1:] Legal proceedings move forward tem[Advance +2:] Players fail to make adequate progress tem[Advance +1:] Supernatural disturbances escalate tem[Advance +2:] Key NPC becomes desperate or hostile tem[When Full:] House declares emergency measures, immediate artifact retrieval required

7.2 Ancient Ward Stability [6]

tem[Advance +1:] Unauthorized entry attempted tem[Advance +1:] Deep Stirrings become more active tem[Advance +2:] Players use force instead of proper ritual tem[Advance +1:] Dwarven customs violated tem[When Full:] Wards collapse, supernatural dangers unleashed

7.3 StoneSong Resonance [4]

tem[Advance +1:] Players approach crypt area tem[Advance +1:] Proper dwarven rituals performed tem[Advance +1:] Deep Stirrings influence area tem[Advance +1:] Players demonstrate respect for dwarven customs tem[When Full:] Artifact calls to return home, supernatural pressure increases

7.4 Dwarven Honor Track

tem[Honored:] +1 die to all dwarven interactions, access to special privileges tem[Respected:] Standard interactions, normal access tem[Doubted:] 1 die to social rolls with dwarves, limited access tem[Shamed:] Hostile reactions, legal consequences, barred from holds

8 Possible Resolutions

8.1 Proper Restoration

Proper Restoration tem[Requirements:]

tem Perform ancient ritual to properly transfer artifact (Craft + Arcana vs DV 6) tem Negotiate new terms satisfying all parties (Sway + Command vs DV 5) tem Gain Deep Stirrings' blessing (Spirit + Lore vs DV 5)

tem[Procedure:] Formal dwarven ceremony with supernatural elements tem[Costs:] Significant time investment, 1 segment Corruption for each participant tem[Outcome:] Honor restored, valuable dwarven allies, potential for future cooperation

8.2 Legal Victory

Legal Victory tem[Discovery:] Original transfer was invalid due to procedural violations tem[Requirements:]

tem Demonstrate procedural violations (Lore vs DV 5) tem Present evidence in dwarven courts (Command + Sway vs DV 5) tem Win legal judgment (Extended social challenge, DV 6)

tem[Procedure:] Formal legal proceedings with all parties present tem[Costs:] Time, potential enemies among traditionalist dwarves tem[Outcome:] Debt canceled, but enemies in traditionalist circles

8.3 Supernatural Compromise

Supernatural Compromise tem[Approach:] Negotiate solution satisfying Deep Stirrings and House KhazVurim tem[Options:]

tem Offer alternative artifact of comparable value (Investigation vs DV 5) tem Agree to perform services for Deep Stirrings (Extended commitment) tem Create new arrangement benefiting all parties (Sway + Insight vs DV 5)

tem[Procedure:] Complex threeway negotiation with ritual elements tem[Costs:] Ongoing obligations, 2 segments Corruption for each participant tem[Outcome:] Mysterious allies, ongoing supernatural connections, unique magical benefits

8.4 Forced Acquisition

Forced Acquisition tem[Approach:] Take artifact by force, deal with consequences tem[Requirements:]
 tem Overcome dwarven security (Combat/Skill challenges, DV 5+) tem Deal with supernatural backlash (Extended Spirit challenge, DV 6) tem Navigate political fallout (Social consequences, 2 Dwarven Honor)

tem[Procedure:] Violent resolution with immediate escape tem[Costs:] Powerful enemies, ongoing supernatural complications, legal consequences tem[Outcome:] Powerful artifact, powerful enemies, ongoing supernatural complications

9 Rewards and Consequences

9.1 Immediate Rewards

tem KeyWrit for operating a named lock: Access to specific secured areas tem Underway Pass for travel between vaultmouths: +1 Position for underground travel tem Engineer Shoring for stabilizing corridors: Prevent cavein once per session tem Assay Mark for dwarven metal recognition: +1 die to identify dwarven craftsmanship tem Crypt Asylum for temporary sanctuary: Safe haven in dwarven territories tem Vault Inventory License for removing items: Legal authority for future acquisitions

9.2 Longterm Consequences

tem **Honored Resolution:** Permanent allies in House KhazVurim, +2 Dwarven Honor, access to master craftsmen tem **Legal Victory:** Respect among progressive dwarves, 1 Dwarven Honor with traditionalists, potential for future legal work tem **Supernatural Compromise:** Ongoing connection to Deep Stirrings, unique magical abilities, 1 permanent Corruption segment tem **Forced Acquisition:** Enemies throughout dwarven realm, 3 Dwarven Honor, powerful artifact but constant supernatural pressure tem **Mixed Outcome:** Complex relationships with all factions, moderate standing, ongoing plot hooks

10 GM Notes

10.1 Dwarven Culture

Emphasize the importance of honor, tradition, and proper procedure in dwarven society. Every interaction should reflect these values:

tem Players respecting customs gain +1 Position tem Violating protocols worsens Position by 1 step tem Proper titles and ceremonies matter for social interactions tem Legal procedures are complex but fair when followed

10.2 Underground Atmosphere

Create a sense of the vast, ancient dwarven realm:

tem Use sound descriptions: distant forges, dripping water, stone settling tem Vary architectural details: smooth ancient stonework vs. rough natural caves tem Describe the weight of stone above, the permanence of underground construction tem Different areas should feel distinct: halls of state vs. working tunnels vs. ancient passages

10.3 Legal Complexity

Dwarven law is intricate and ancient:

tem Multiple precedents exist for most situations tem Specific procedures must be followed for validity tem Contracts can have unexpected interpretations tem Legal experts (like ClanSpeaker) can find creative solutions

10.4 Supernatural Elements

The Deep Stirrings represent patient, ancient supernatural forces:

tem Prefer manipulation to direct confrontation tem Communicate through dreams, stonework, and omens tem Have waited decades for proper resolution tem Are not inherently evil, but have different priorities

10.5 Player Agency

Provide multiple paths to resolution:

tem Legal approach: Navigate dwarven law system tem Social approach: Negotiate with all factions tem Investigation approach: Discover true history and find creative solutions tem Direct action approach: Force resolution through power

10.6 Story Beats

Use dwarven environment and customs for complications:

tem 1 SB: Minor procedural violation, small legal complication tem 2 SB: Important NPC becomes suspicious, document goes missing tem 3 SB: Cavein blocks path, ancient guardian activates tem 4+ SB: Major faction turns hostile, supernatural manifestation occurs

10.7 SessionSpecific Guidance

Session 1 Focus: Establish dwarven legal/cultural framework. Players should understand the debt is legitimate but complex.

Session 2 Focus: Introduce supernatural elements and underground challenges. Players learn there's more to this than simple contract law.

Session 3 Focus: Deep supernatural contact and moral complexity. Players must balance competing legitimate claims.

Session 4 Focus: Climactic resolution and consequences. All previous elements converge in final choices.

10.8 Alternative Endings

If players fail to achieve clean resolution:

tem **Partial Success:** Temporarily satisfy one faction while creating new problems tem
Compromise: Artifact remains in limbo, ongoing tension between factions tem **Pyrrhic**
Victory: Solve immediate problem but create worse longterm issues tem **Escalation:** Situ-
ation becomes larger conflict involving multiple dwarven houses

10.9 Scaling for Different Tiers

Tier II (Seasoned): Reduce entity Caps, simplify legal procedures, provide more NPC assistance.

Tier III (Veteran): Add political complications, increase entity power, complicate legal requirements.

Tier IV (Paragon): Introduce kingdomlevel political implications, multiple simultaneous conflicts, entity gains patron backing.